



long-pimples side (conventionally the backhand side for the Indians) is used to dampen the spin while the smooth (forehand side) imparts it. If she doesn't twiddle, Sreeja can become very predictable.

"If I play only with the pimples side instead of changing the pace of the ball (by flipping the playing side of the bat) then it's not easy for me to beat the top players," she says, while explaining the need to use the technique, which, although challenging to pull off, will keep her opponents off balance trying to adjust to various types of balls coming from both sides.

While Manika is adept in the technique, Sreeja is still perfecting the skill. But as her match against Cheng showed, she's gaining confidence steadily. "I've been practising this for some time but I've not had a lot of confidence while trying it in a match.

This time I used it a lot against Cheng. I know I missed a lot of balls because I was trying out something new; I've never done it so much as I did today. But I'm happy that I was bold enough to do it," she said.

It's not just her twiddling that could create some doubt in the minds of opponents at Busan. "My forehand attack has improved a lot. It's become very powerful. I am also moving really quick. So that's also a positive," she says. As the all-important World Team Championships looms around the corner, India will hope an ever reliable Batra instills a renewed sense of belief in the rest of the team. The results in Goa have gone a long way towards that. It allows the team to focus on putting all their efforts towards that tournament rather than having to think about the singles qualifying tournament they might have to play should they fail to make

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the cut as a team.

"Because of the increase in our rankings, our seeding will improve not just for the World Team Championships but also for the singles qualifier afterwards (in May). It also gives us a chance to go through (in the final shot at qualifying) based on ranking.

"Because of this we don't have to play any more WTT tournaments. We of course have to play the World Championships and the singles qualifying tournaments, but apart from that we can now focus on our training completely," Sreeja says.